



PLANKTON

Seawater is full of billions of very tiny living things called plankton. Most are less than 0.04 inches (one millimeter) long, but without them, very little else could live in the sea! Clouds of microscopic algae called phytoplankton drift

around at the mercy of tides and currents.

They are eaten by swarms of tiny animals called zooplankton, and these are then eaten by fish, whales, and even seabirds.



Bucket full!

Copepods are a type of zooplankton.

They are so small that more than one million could fit into a bucket of seawater.



Phytoplankton...eaten by...zooplankton...eaten by...fish...eaten by...seabirds

Food for everyone

Seabirds, turtles, and seals all eat other animals, such as fish and shellfish, that eat plankton.

They would all starve if there were no plankton in the sea.

Part-time plankton

Some animals begin their lives as tiny plankton, but then they grow much, much bigger.

Crab



Starfish

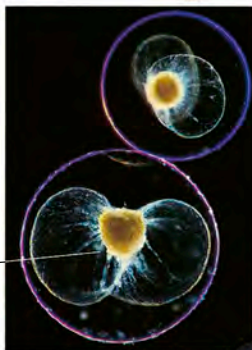


Octopus



This curved feeler is covered in fine sensory hairs which help the copepod find food.

Zooplankton are tiny animals, but they are much bigger than most phytoplankton.



Microscopic phytoplankton absorb the energy of the sun as they float along.

Sun lovers

Like land plants, phytoplankton use sunlight to make their food.

There are many different sorts, or species, of copepods. This male is flashing bright blue to attract a female.